Upon This Rock (Core Values) (6)

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This morning we continue our study of “Upon This Rock” If we are going to build up the church, that is, strive towards our vision through our mission, we must do so by valuing the right things.

Vision:

Cedar Grove Baptist Church exists to create a space where people and families can *meet* Jesus, *find* community, and *grow* in their faith.

Mission:

Our purpose is to *love* others unconditionally, *learn* about God increasingly, *live* to share Jesus intentionally and *lead* others to Christ continually in Lebanon, TN and throughout the whole world.

These are not simply statements to memorize, but rather we must live these out. I do want to encourage you this morning. I have had the blessing of being able to meet with several of the families who have been visiting Cedar Grove.

If there is one common denominator on why these families came back and continue to come it is this: our church feels like a family…it is obvious that we do not gather out of simple obligation, but rather out of the desire to be with each other… there is joy in the house of the Lord here at Cedar Grove!

And you know what is beautiful about this? That is exactly what God desires from the local church.

This does not mean that we do not have occasional conflict or tension, but what it shows is that we keep the purpose of our gatherings at the front of our hearts and minds. Why are we here?

We talked about this in our core value of commitment a few weeks ago…

Hebrews 10:23–25 NKJV

[23] Let us hold fast the confession of *our* hope without wavering, for He who promised *is* faithful. [24] And let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works,

[25] not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as *is* the manner of some, but exhorting *one another,* and so much the more as you see the Day approaching.

Let me tell you, if we gather with joy in our hearts grateful for the unity we have in Christ, this is exactly what will happen!

I do want to give a word of caution here before we get going on our next core value…

If you find yourself coming to church without that joy that we are talking about. That joy that Paul speaks of in Philippians 2:2

Philippians 2:2 NKJV

[2] fulfill my joy by being like-minded, having the same love, *being* of one accord, of one mind.

Could it be that it is not always a church problem? We have to realize that a church is made up of broken people growing in their faith. That is a process. Spiritual maturity does not happen overnight. That does not mean that we stay where we are spiritually, we are expected to grow.

But just because you may be further along in your faith than someone else does not give you the right to discount that person's faith.

So if you come to church and you lack a joy of being with your church family look inward not outward first. What we are doing right now is a gift…it is a blessing designed by God for our benefit and His glory.

This morning we move on to our 6th Core Value.

Accountability

This is a word that if you have been in church long enough you almost roll your eyes when you hear it. What does accountability even mean in the church? How do you

successfully implement accountability in the church? Is it even possible?

Listen, these are not bad questions. These are questions that if asked with the correct heart can lead to proper accountability within our church family.

So, our statement of agreement for this Core Value:

I will exhibit accountability in my relationship with Christ and with fellow believers

Pray.

There are many different ways to define accountability, however, I appreciate how the Bible Hub defines it…

Accountability, in a biblical context, refers to the responsibility of individuals to answer for their actions, decisions, and stewardship before God and, at times, before others. It encompasses the idea that humans are answerable to God for their moral and ethical conduct, as well as their use of the resources and talents entrusted to them.

Notice from our statement of agreement and the definition that this is a two part process.

First, we must be accountable to our walk with Christ. This involves personal accountability.

Second, we must be accountable to others. This is public or corporate accountability.

This morning we will break down these two parts.

How will we exhibit accountability in my relationship with Christ and with fellow believers?

By growing daily in the grace and knowledge of the Lord Jesus Christ and submitting to His Lordship

There are some doctrinal words that we as believers need to know.

Three words that have a direct connection to you…

Justification. Sanctification. Glorification.

What is justification?

Justification is God declaring a person righteous.

This is a big deal because by nature we are in fact unrighteous.

Romans 3:10 NASB95
10 as it is written, "THERE IS NONE RIGHTEOUS, NOT EVEN ONE;

So, how does one become justified in the sight of God?

Romans 5:1 NASB95
1 Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,…

We are saved by grace through faith and in the same moment we are declared righteous by God. This is a legal standing before God the Righteous Judge.

In words, when you get saved you become justified by God through Jesus Christ

Okay, so what is sanctification?

The word "Sanctify" speaks on

something or someone being set apart for holiness

This is where we get the term "saint" from

We know that sanctification is the will of God for our life and even gives us an example of how

1 Thessalonians 4:3–7 NASB95
3 For this is the will of God, your sanctification; *that is,* that you abstain from sexual immorality; 4 that each of you know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor, 5 not in lustful passion, like the Gentiles who do not know God;

[6] *and* that no man transgress and defraud his brother in the matter because the Lord is *the* avenger in all these things, just as we also told you before and solemnly warned *you.* [7] For God has not called us for the purpose of impurity, but in sanctification.

That term here in the greek specifically means

Lexham Theological Wordbook ἁγιασμός

ἁγιασμός (hagiasmos). n. masc. **sanctification, holiness, consecration.** Refers either to the process of becoming holy, by which the state of holiness is attained, or to the end result that the sanctifying work has obtained.

This is a process. But the end result will be us being full holy. This is where glorification comes occurs.

Glorification is God's final removal of sin from the life of the saints in the eternal state

This is the hope that we cling to as believers.

It is the hope that Paul spoke of

2 Corinthians 4:17–18 NKJV

[17] For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, is working for us a far more exceeding *and* eternal weight of glory,

[18] while we do not look at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen. For the things which are seen *are* temporary, but the things which are not seen *are* eternal

Glorification is when we become like Christ completely in heaven. Not that we become gods ourself, but we will in that moment be perfect image-bearers. What a day that will be! This is the completion of God restoring us to how things were before the fall in the garden.

Now, is there a way we can simplify this down even more? Because all of this has to do with salvation, which is the deepest work of God. Let me try…

Justification tells is that we have been saved.

Sanctification tells is that we are being saved.

Glorification tells us we will be saved.

Out it all together…because we have put our faith in Jesus we are completely and all the way SAVED!

Okay, now, being saved means that we are accountable in how we steward our walk with the Lord.

How? Again,…

By growing daily in the grace and knowledge of the Lord Jesus Christ and submitting to His Lordship

You are not being accountable in your relationship with Jesus if you are not growing increasingly in grace and knowledge.

We must have a forward direction of our walk…

Philippians 3:12 NASB95

12 Not that I have already obtained *it* or have already become perfect, but I press on so that I may lay hold of that for which also I was laid hold of by Christ Jesus.

Paul continues…

Philippians 3:13–14 NASB95

13 Brethren, I do not regard myself as having laid hold of *it* yet; but one thing *I do:* forgetting what *lies* behind and reaching forward to what *lies* ahead, 14 I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.

Do not forget who is writing this? The Apostle Paul at this time would have been in ministry for around 25-30 years. He had been through massive and intense ministry journeys, authored several epistles, he had been shipwrecked, beat, imprisoned multiple times. He has seen the highest of highs and the lowest of lows.

But he knew that even then, even after all the time already spent, he can still grow

closer to Jesus. He can still be more like Him. There is still more to learn about the unsearchable God!

So what was his challenge to his fellow believers…us?

Philippians 3:15–17 NASB95

15 Let us therefore, as many as are perfect, have this attitude; and if in anything you have a different attitude, God will reveal that also to you;

16 however, let us keep living by that same *standard* to which we have attained. 17 Brethren, join in following my example, and observe those who walk according to the pattern you have in us.

What is God revealing to you today?

One of the greatest shames we have tolerated in the church is a lack of growth in the faith. “Well, some things are just too complicated.” Okay, study harder!

“I Just don’t have time to look into anything else…” Okay, tear down the idols in your life that keep you from spending time with Jesus!

The excuses we make to stay a babe in Christ should humiliate us.

If all you know is all you want to know than you need to know Jesus better. Repeat.

This personal effort and challenge from Paul comes from desiring to know more.

Philippians 3:7–11 NASB95

7 But whatever things were gain to me, those things I have counted as loss for the sake of Christ.

8 More than that, I count all things to be loss in view of the surpassing value of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them but rubbish so that I may gain Christ,

9 and may be found in Him, not having a righteousness of my own derived from *the* Law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which *comes* from God on the basis of faith,

[10] that I may know Him and the power of His resurrection and the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to His death; [11] in order that I may attain to the resurrection from the dead.

We must take personal accountability for our walk with Christ. You know how you can go to church week in and week out and not experience any growth? Because you have not made Jesus priority. You simply do not want to.

Colossians 1:18 NASB95
[18] He is also head of the body, the church; and He is the beginning, the firstborn from the dead, so that He Himself will come to have first place in everything

Have you submitted to His Lordship? Does He have first place in everything in your life?

I will exhibit accountability in my relationship with Christ and with fellow believers

By growing daily in the grace and knowledge of the Lord Jesus Christ and submitting to His Lordship

on to the next part…

By beginning and growing accountability partnerships with fellow believers

I have spent a lot of time on this first part because if you are not willing to keep yourself accountable it is difficult for others to hold you accountable. However, it is still part of being in the family.

This is not a fun or easy thing to do.

Proverbs uses strong illustrative language to convey this truth.

Proverbs 27:17 NASB95
[17] Iron sharpens iron, So one man sharpens another.

We see all throughout scripture believers holding other believers accountable in their faith.

Nathan confronts King David

Paul confronts Peter

Barnabas and Paul disagree and confront each other

Paul corrects Euodia and Syntyche by name

Paul holds Timothy to a higher standard

All of the epistles and the letters we find in the Bible can be viewed and should be viewed as a way to keep the reader accountable to the truth.

Now, we are to do this with grace and love. scripture makes that clear. Galatians 6:1

Galatians 6:1 NASB95

[1] Brethren, even if anyone is caught in any trespass, you who are spiritual, restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness; *each one* looking to yourself, so that you too will not be tempted.

You know what has happened today in the church? We would rather look over a fellow members sin rather than cover it with Bible rebuke and accountability.

We have turned the phrase “keep the peace” into an excuse to not say what needs to be said. I am guilty of this as well.

The worst part of this is the result.

The church today is full of dull Christians. Believers who haven’t taken any further steps in their faith. Saints who are riddled with sinful habits that think its okay.

I have heard the saying too much of “you wanna grow a church, do not preach on sin…”

In other words, do not hold the people accountable.

Can i tell you right now….the truth is in the inverse of that statement.

You wanna grow *the* church, preach on sin.

Let the Word of God do its work on us!

It cannot only come from the pulpit, it must come from each other.

How sharp are we Cedar Grove? Have we grown dull?

Proverbs 27:17 NASB95

17 Iron sharpens iron, So one man sharpens another.